CYBER SECURITY 101

CHECKLIST PACK · 2026

MFA & Passkey Setup Checklist Pack

Step-by-step checklists for Google, Apple, Microsoft, email, bank, and carrier accounts — plus a recovery-codes worksheet so you're ready if your phone is lost or replaced.

6 platform checklists
Google · Apple · Microsoft · email · carrier · banks

3 worksheets
Recovery codes, account tracker, lost-phone plan

Plain English
The MFA ladder and passkeys, explained

SOURCED TO CISA · NIST SP 800-63B-4 · FTC · FCC · Google · Apple · Microsoft help

START HERE

What's inside

Do the 60-minute plan once. Then use the quarterly review to keep it that way.

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HOW TO USE THIS PACK

1. Read the **ladder** and **passkeys** pages.
2. Follow the **60-minute plan** — email first.
3. Fill in the **worksheets** as you go (type in the PDF or print).

PROTECT YOUR WORKSHEETS

Completed recovery pages are as sensitive as a passport. Store printed copies somewhere safe (not your wallet), and don't save filled-in copies in the same account they protect.

Educational information, not legal advice. This guide summarizes publicly available guidance from U.S. government sources (FTC, CISA, NIST, FBI/IC3) and official vendor help pages as checked in September 2026. Menus, settings, and services change often — when a step does not match your screen, follow the linked official help page. Nothing here guarantees you will not be targeted or harmed by fraud. For legal, financial, or regulatory decisions, consult a qualified professional.

CORE CONCEPT

The MFA ladder

Multi-factor authentication (MFA, also called two-step verification or 2FA) means a stolen password alone isn't enough to get in. But not all second steps are equal. CISA ranks the common methods from most to least secure:

5 **Security key / passkey** PHISHING-RESISTANT

CISA ranks a physical security key first — "the best protection against phishing." Passkeys use the same FIDO/WebAuthn standard and are also phishing-resistant (NIST, FIDO Alliance): tied to the real website, so a fake site can't use them.

4 **Authenticator app with number matching** STRONG

You type or select the number shown on the login screen into the app — which makes blind "Approve" taps much harder.

3 **Authenticator app one-time code** GOOD

A 6-digit code that changes every 30 seconds. Much better than text messages, but can still be typed into a fake site.

2 **Biometrics** DEVICE-SPECIFIC

Fingerprint or face confirms it's you — usually unlocking something on your device. CISA: best used with another method.

1 **Text or email code** WEAKEST — BUT BETTER THAN NOTHING

Can be phished, and text codes can be redirected through SIM-swap scams (FTC). Use only when nothing stronger is offered.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Any MFA beats none (CISA). Turn on whatever an account offers today, then climb the ladder: passkeys or security keys where available, an authenticator app everywhere else, and text codes only as a last resort.

What NIST says: NIST SP 800-63B-4 states that methods where you manually type a code — one-time passwords from an app or text — are *not* considered phishing-resistant, while WebAuthn/FIDO2 (the standard behind passkeys and security keys) provides phishing resistance. It also no longer considers acceptable simple "approve" prompts that don't require transferring a code or number between screens, citing "authentication fatigue" attacks.